hid from predators in the dense undergrowth of the chaparral shrubland. However, a niche is more complex than simply the place where an organism lives. Oxpeckers and buffalo share exactly the same habitat—open grassland – but their requirements for survival are very different: the buffalo graze on the grasses, while oxpeckers derive their food from the ticks they peck from the buffalos' hide.

Charles Elton explored the concept of ecological niches in more depth. For him, food was the primary factor in defining an animal's niche. What it ate and what it was eaten by were crucial. Depending on the habitat, a particular niche could be filled by a different animal. Elton cited the example of a niche that was filled by birds of prey that hunted small ground-dwelling animals such as mice and voles. In a European oakwood, that niche would be filled by Tawny Owls, while on open grassland Kestrels would fill the role.

Elton also argued that an animal could not only tolerate a certain set of environmental conditions, but could also change them. The tree-felling and stream-damming activity of beavers is one of the most dramatic examples, creating habitats for fish in dammed pools, woodpeckers in dead trees, and dragonflies around pool margins.